

Corel Paint Shop Pro Photo XI

Some of this, some of that

Adobe has been well-known mostly for Photoshop. CorelDraw and later Jasc Software's Paint Shop Pro were competition back then. Jasc was taken over by Corel, and Paint Shop Pro has been developed by Corel ever since. We put Corel's latest release of Paint Shop Pro Photo—version XI—to the test to see if the "Photo" tag at the end of the name has any substance to it.

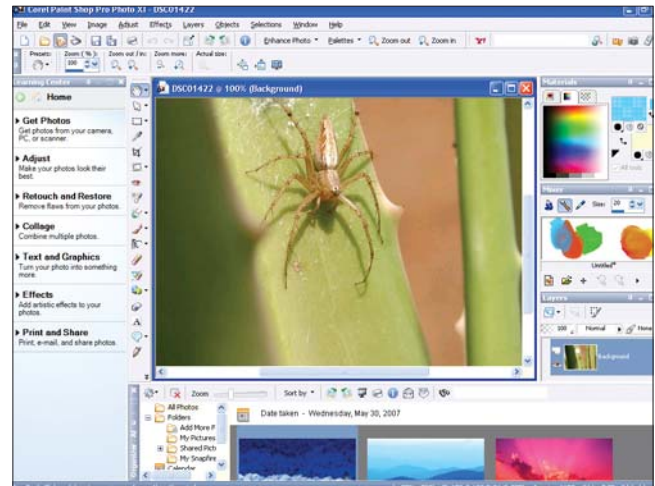
The interface is pretty cluttered with toolbars, organisers, and help panels, leaving little space to actually work on. It's a good thing you can turn them off. There are tons of features, but we didn't really find a lot specifically made for photograph manipulation. Skin smoothing, red-eye removal, and digital camera noise removal were some that would be useful for photographers. A button called "Enhance Photo"

brings in additional features that find the best parameters for a photo.

We found traces of features from other Corel products—Painter, for example. Paint Shop Pro Photo has a mixer that lets you add certain amounts of colours and mix them about till you get the right shade. Another feature is the option to choose the texture of the canvas when you create a new image.

The software isn't much of a memory hog, unlike some image editing tools where memory consumption goes well over three digits in megabytes. The software peaked out at a moderate 77 MB of RAM with four images open and some effects in place.

The Windows help documentation explains all of Paint Shop Pro Photo's features with screenshots as well as the icons you find in the interface. The learning bar explains features and



also gets tasks done in quick steps without you having to go through multiple menus and windows.

If you need a software specifically for photo

manipulation, Adobe's Lightroom is the better choice. Paint Shop Pro Photo seems more like a contemporary of Photoshop. The price is \$89.99—less than half that of Lightroom—and could be well worth it if you want something that can tweak photos and also edit images.

Web site: www.corel.com
Price : Rs \$89.99 (Rs 3,600)

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Ease of Use	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

xplorer² 1.6.5.3

A cool replacement for Explorer

Here's a utility that claims it has the features to make file handling and disk exploring much simpler and less repetitive than with Windows Explorer.

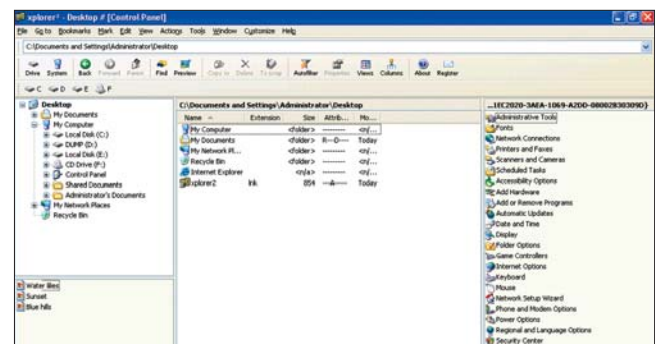
When the program is first run, you are informed about some plugins that might be required to display information on formats such as PDF and MP3.

Unlike the classic Windows Explorer view where you have two panes, xplorer² gives you three, which means more flexibility. You do have the option to revert to two panes.

The interface, like in Windows Explorer, is modular, so you can disable toolbars you don't need. xplorer² keeps track of all the locations you've been visiting, and you can easily

jump back to any of them with two clicks. Filters are implemented in the program, so you can choose to only view files of a certain format, such as Excel spreadsheets. If you find any files interesting and want to access them later, you can do so by dragging and dropping them into a temporary location called a scrap container, which creates within it links to those files.

Other features include file and folder comparison, and the option to collapse all folders so only the files



from all the subdirectories are listed together. For example, if you have separate folders full of images, xplorer² will let you view all the images as if they were in one big folder. A feature called Sticky Selection lets you click all the files you want to select without having to hold down the [Ctrl] or [Shift] keys. Quick Viewer is a panel that allows you to view the contents of a file without having to open it. Data transfer rates are displayed

during copying and moving as well.

Memory consumption is very low, at around 500 to 700 KB when minimised and around 3 MB when maximised.

We can sum up xplorer² as being Windows Explorer on steroids. It is priced at \$29.95 (Rs 1,350), which might be worth it if you're willing to make the jump considering it will take some time to get used to it.

Web site: www.zabkat.com
Price: \$29.95 (Rs 1,350)

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Ease of Use	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★